



» NITESH KUMAR

Category: Badminton (Men's Singles SL3)

Pramod Bhagat had achieved a remarkable milestone by winning the first-ever Paralympic gold medal in badminton at the Tokyo Games, claiming the men's singles SL3 category title with a victory over Great Britain's Daniel Bethell.

Three years later in Paris, Bethell faced an Indian player once again, but it was not Bhagat — who was suspended for breaching the Badminton World Federation's anti-doping regulations — but Nitesh Kumar, a Paralympic debutant.

The 29-year-old Nitesh ensured the gold stayed with India by saving a match point and clinching a 21-14, 18-21, 23-21 victory over the second-seeded Bethell. This win marked Nitesh's first-ever victory over Bethell in their 10 encounters.

"I have lost in such situations against him before, and I didn't want to repeat the same mistakes. I had lost my composure in the past, so I told myself to keep fighting for every point. At 19-20 in the decider, I reminded myself to stay focused and make him earn each point," Nitesh said after his win.

SL3 class players, who have severe lower limb disabilities, play on a half-width court, hitting the shuttle on only one side of the field. Nitesh lost his left leg in a train accident in 2009.

Inspired by Bhagat during his time at IIT Mandi, Nitesh took up the sport and began his competitive journey in 2016 at the nationals in Faridabad. He faced Bhagat in the final of the 2022 World Championships, losing in two tight games.

At the Asian Para Games in Hangzhou last year, Nitesh showcased his talent by winning gold in men's doubles, silver in singles, and bronze in mixed doubles.